

AJEYA

FADE IN:

OVER AN ANCIENT MAP OF HINDUSTAN SHOWING VARIOUS EMPIRES OF THE TIME:

NARRATOR (V.O.)

When Shivaji Maharaj lit the flame of Swaraj, many brave-heart warriors from across the great Maratha land joined him. The fledgling empire was surrounded from all sides by Mughals, the Nizam Shahi, and the Adil Shahis. They have carved the land among themselves like a pack of wolves rip a prey into pieces. It was important to unite the people of the land and build an empire, one fort at a time.

SLATE: "Do your duty and leave the rest to Heaven".

INT./EXT. RAIGADH/SHIVAJI'S FORT - FORT WALL - DAWN

From atop the fort wall we see a golden sun rising on the great Maratha land.

TWO SENTRIES on beat on the fort wall notice a tiny form approaching. As the form nears the gates it is clear that it is an INJURED MAN, BARELY ABLE TO PUT ONE FOOT IN FRONT OF THE OTHER.

The injured man waves at the gate and collapses.

The giant gates open with a rumble as guards step out.

As they get closer, they see--

A YOUNG MAN (early 20's) wounded, an ARROW LODGED DEEP IN HIS LEFT SHOULDER.

INT. RAIGADH/SHIVAJI'S FORT - DAY

A guard splashes water on the injured man's face and pours some into his mouth. The injured man suffocates, coughs blood and water. In a faint breath he utters: *Maharaj*.

As the men tend to the wounds of the injured man, SHIVAJI arrives. Dressed in resplendent silks and Maratha pagdi, Shivaji is as gentle as he is ferocious. He cradles the injured man in his lap.

SHIVAJI
Who did this to you, brave one?

INT. BAJI PRABHU'S RESIDENCE - COURTYARD - DAY

A LARGE SQUARE FILLED WITH MUD where soldiers practice with WOODEN versions of the weapons lined on the wall. Older fighters mentoring young ones.

These are not teenage boys learning the ropes of sword fight, but battle-hardened men whose faces are wrinkled with experience of impossible battles, palms calloused from wielding weapons. These are the finest and fiercest fighters of the land.

Beyond the mud square an entrance leads us to...

ALTERNATE SCENE

An unusually TALL AND WIDE GATE for a residence. We move inside the gate to--

A CROWD ERUPTS AROUND A LARGE MUD SQUARE, AN ARENA. As we move closer we see--

MOROJI (40's) PUMMELING VISHBA (20's) with a wooden sword. a PRACTICE REPLICA of the real WEAPONS LINED AGAINST THE WALL close by.

Vishba, a lean mean son of a gun, has his eyes set on Moroji's ribs, waiting for a chance to attack.

Confident of his victory Moroji raises his sword high to deliver a killer blow.

Before Moroji brings his sword down, Vishba draws a dagger hidden in his waist and with feather-lite footwork stabs thrice in the exposed rib section.

VISHBA
You're dead.

He moves behind Moroji, to the other side and stabs him again.

VISHBA (cont'd)
You're dead again, old man.

Moroji, locks Vishba's head with this left arm and throws him in front.

MOROJI

(furious)

You and your tricks! Fight me from the front!

VISHBA

Doesn't matter. You're a dead man now.

The crowd ERUPTS again. TATYA (60's) is amused.

Moroji throws a volley of blows at Vishba.

Vishba leads Moroji around the arena, deflecting the his blows. Tiring him in the process.

INT. BAJI PRABHU'S RESIDENCE - TEMPLE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

We enter the residential complex, we see the back of a towering personality offering flowers to the deity.

BAJI PRABHU

*Om Swasti Saamrajyam
Bhaujyam Swaaraajyam...
Vairaaajyam Paarameshthyam...*

Beside him stands his WIFE elegantly dressed in a NINE-YARD SARI, holding a PLATE FULL OF FLOWERS.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)

*Om Ekadantaya Vidmahe
Vakratundaya Dhimahi*

Tanno Dantih Prachodayat

He offers a handful of flowers from the plat to the Gods and finishes his morning prayer. This is BAJI PRABHU (50s). Standing over six feet, body scarred with battle stories.

He wears his sandals and makes his way in to--

INT. BAJI PRABHU'S RESIDENCE - COURTYARD - CONTINUOUS

TATYA (65) notices Baji Prabhu approaching, and greets him.

TATYA

Baji, one more family has left the village last night. They received no justice from Krishnaji Bandal.

(MORE)

TATYA (cont'd)

(beat)

Why does a man of your honour
continue to serve such a man?

BAJI PRABHU

In a world of constantly changing of
allegiances, a man's promise must
mean something, Tatya. My father
swore to protect the Bandals.
As his son, I will honour my father's
promise till my death.

The CROWD ERUPTS again. Gets Baji prabhu's attention.

He walks towards the arena.

ARENA

Vishba jumps high in the air and brings down his wooden
sword with all his might on Moroji.

Moroji doesn't flinch. He parries, with a horizontal slice.
Vishba serves blow after blow, pushing Moroji backwards.

Moroji steps backward, fielding blows till there's no more
place for maneuvering--just as Vishba planned.

Vishba locks swords with Moroji and attacks Moroji's ribs
again and again and again.

Baji Prabhu is amused with the boy's agility and ability to
manipulate his opponent.

Baji walks closer, the soldiers part way -- Moroji and
Vishba stop fighting.

Vishba lowers his weapons and bows to Baji.

BAJI PRABHU

Moroji, I have not seen anyone corner
you in a long time. who is this young
one?

MOROJI

Baji, this is my son, Vishba.

Vishba touches Baji Prabhu's feet.

MOROJI (cont'd)

He has been brought up with bedtime
stories of your valor and skill.

Baji Prabhu lifts Vishba from his feet.

MOROJI (cont'd)
From childhood he wanted to grow up
to be a fighter like you.

BAJI PRABHU
(studying the boy)
How old is he?

MOROJI
He just turned 20.

BAJI PRABHU
He is too young to fight, Moroji.
This is the time for him to learn,
wed and taste a family life. The
world is treacherous enough, he have
ample fights to take part in.

MOROJI
As soldiers of the land, we learn to
fight. We yearn to fight. For honour,
for pride. And is there anything more
honorable than to fight for you, who
is the greatest warrior of this land?

BAJI PRABHU
Ma Bhavani has blessed us to be the
protectors of these hills. She gives
us the strength and the will to do
so. But Vishba here is too young to
see and face death.

VISHBA
Raje, I do not value the life of a
family man, but the honour to fight
for you, to fight beside you. If Ma
Bhavani is generous, I will see a
family life when she grants it to me.
All my life, all I wanted was to
fight for you.

BAJI PRABHU
Well, then let's see how well you can
fight with real weapons.

Baji Prabhu walks to the weapons lined by the wall.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)
Come, Vishba. Pick any weapon of your
choice.

Vishba looks at Moroji, Moroji nods at his son.

Vishba picks a *patta*.

VISHBA

I have heard many stories of your skill with the patta, Raje. I too have learned to wield it.

BAJI PRABHU

Then let's see what your father has taught you.

Baji Prabhu drops the shawl from his shoulders, picks up a shield and enters the arena.

Vishba follows Baji Prabhu into the arena. Both the men face each other as other soldiers watch anxiously.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)

Go on.

Vishba squeezes the pommel of his sword, locks his eyes with Baji Prabhu and lunges at him serving a volley of firm blows.

Baji deflects Vishba's sword with his shield, moving around the arena, not offering any chance to Vishba to pin him down like he did with his father.

They step back, moving in unison. Vishba looking for opportune moment to surprise Baji with his dagger.

Vishba charges at Baji again, serves a series of firm thrusts, all landing in the shield.

Baji with his shield is a wall that Vishba is unable to pierce. Baji deflects the sword and locks his arm under his left arm, their faces close, staring at each other. perfect time for Vishba to draw his hidden dagger--

With his free left hand, Vishba draws his dagger and goes for Baji's ribs.

Baji catches Vishba's hand midway.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)

You can't surprise me.

Baji lets go of Vishba's sword arm and pushes Vishba back with the shield.

Baji's turn -- He lunges forward with the shield and delivers a barrage of blows as if it were a hammer. Vishba tumbles backward, unable to hold off the brute force brought upon him by the shield.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)

Get up.

Vishba regains his composure, locks his eyes on Baji and as he prepares his attack--

We hear SOUND OF HOOVES OF HORSES. Baji Prabhu is distracted.

The boy seizes the opportunity and delivers a blow. Baji Prabhu brings up his shield, but a microsecond late. The sword slides on the shield and leaves a gash on his shoulder, letting a STREAM OF BLOOD.

A GROUP OF RIDERS arrive through the gates.

Moroji rushes to tend to Baji prabhu's wound.

MOROJI

Please accept my apologies. My son can sometimes be unruly.

(looking angrily at Vishba)

He shouldn't have struck when you were distracted.

BAJI PRABHU

Enemy doesn't wait till you are attentive, Moroji. You son has an eye for opponent's weaknesses. A distraction is a weakness on a battle field.

Moroji holds a piece of cloth against the wound.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)

He has the strength you had twenty years ago. He can be a worthy addition to our force.

Moroji looks at his son proudly. Vishba is elated. He touches Baji Prabhu's feet.

MOROJI

He won't let you down.

PHULAJI (60's), Baji Prabhu's elder brother, alights from his horse. Tatya greets him.

BAJI PRABHU

(to Phulaji)

Dada, what is the reason for your sudden visit?

PHULAJI

Baji, Krishnaji Bandal sent me to fetch you. Take your best men and ride with me to Rohida Fort. We are expecting an attack soon.

BAJI PRABHU

By whom?

PHULAJI

Shivaji. His men have already raided lands around the fort. It is only a matter of time before he attacks the fort.

BAJI PRABHU

(to Moroji)

Ready our men.

(To Phulaji)

Let's go inside while my men get ready.

INT. BAJI PRABHU'S RESIDENCE - LIVING ROOM - DAY

As Baji Prabhu enters the house with Phulaji, Tatya and others, his wife notices the wound on his shoulder and holds the edge of her sari against the wound.

BAJI PRABHU'S WIFE

(to a maid)

Bring some turmeric paste.

She tears a piece of her sari and wipes the blood off Baji Prabhu's. A maid arrives with a bowl of turmeric. She begins patching the wound with the paste.

BAJI PRABHU

(to his wife)

This is a *rangoli* decoration on my body. Nothing you have to worry so much about.

(to Phulaji)

Are the repairs to the fort done?

PHULAJI

No. Krishnaji says Baji Prabhu is all the defence the fort needs.

BAJI PRABHU'S WIFE

Shivaji must be a mad man to even think of attacking Adil Shah's fort.

PHULAJI

Shivaji has been rapidly carving out lands that belong to the Mughals in the North and Adil Shah in the South. He wants to free the lands from Muslim rulers and create a Maratha empire. He is calling it the fight for Swarajya. We hear that many Maratha warriors have joined him in the fight for his cause.

Moroji intrudes the conversation--

MOROJI

(to Baji Prabhu)

Our men are ready.

As Baji Prabhu and the men stand to leave--

Baji Prabhu's wife brings arti and applies a vermilion tilak on his forehead.

BAJI PRABHU'S WIFE

May the God give you the strength to protect your king.

PHULAJI

(to Baji Prabhu's wife)

Shivaji may have won forts before, but this time he will have to face Baji Prabhu.

Baji Prabhu strides out into--

EXT. BAJI PRABHU'S RESIDENCE - COURTYARD - CONTINUOUS

A contingent of SOLDIERS ARMED AND MOUNTED on their horses, ready to ride out.

Baji Prabhu notices Vishba standing on the sidelines.

BAJI PRABHU

(to Vishba)

Ma Bhavani has granted your wish sooner. Come, ride out with us. We will need a warrior like you.

Elated at the invitation, Vishba bows to Baji Prabhu. Moroji is ecstatic.

Phulaji's ten men lead the contingent followed by Baji Prabhu's fifty men.

In the middle Baji Prabhu rides alongside Vishba. Vishba looks back at his father riding behind them who is filled with pride.

Tatya rides the rear guard.

INT./EXT. ROHIDA FORT - DAY

The gates of Rohida Fort OPEN as Phulaji approaches with sixty men in tow. Inside the gates, is KRISHNAJI BANDAL (65) a bull of a man, built short and bulky, welcomes Baji Prabhu.

Krishnaji is happy and relieved to see Baji Prabhu arrive with his best men to defend his fort.

KRISHNAJI BANDAL
Come, Baji. The sight of you brings
solace to my weary heart.

Baji Prabhu and Phulaji alight their horses.

BAJI PRABHU
Pranaam, Raje.

KRISHNAJI BANDAL
I know you will never fail to answer
the call to defend your kingdom. With
you brothers on my side, even a
hundred Shivajis can't breach the
fort gates. Come, we must prepare our
defences. There is no time. We may be
attacked anytime now.

BAJI PRABHU
But why does Shivaji want to attack
our fort?

KRISHNAJI BANDAL
He is a mad man. Few days ago we
received a messenger.

BAJI PRABHU
What was he message?

KRISHNAJI BANDAL
'Denounce your allegiance to Adil
Shah and join us in Swarajya movement
and we will let you keep the fort.'
Obviously I refused.

Baji Prabhu ponders. A hint of worry on his face.

BAJI PRABHU

You did the right thing, Raje.

(beat)

Eleven days to *amavasya*. The attack will come on the night of *amavasya*. We must prepare our defences.

KRISHNAJI BANDAL

How do you know?

BAJI PRABHU

I would choose the same night of *amavasya* if I were to attack this fort.

INT. RAIGADH - SHIVAJI'S FORT - COURTROOM - DAY

An ASSEMBLY. Shivaji is joined by his legendary Generals NETAJI PALKAR, JEDDE, and MALUSURE, and his minister PANT.

SHIVAJI

Pant, what do we know about defences in Rohida fort ?

PANT

Maharaj, our spy tells me the fort isn't big but it is in a strategic location. It is held by about two hundred men, all who fight under the leadership of Krishnaji Bandal, the *Killedar* of Adil Shah.

People are fed-up with his reckless actions and many of them are fleeing the kingdom. So ater we take the fort, there will be no resistance from people there.

The rear wall of the fort partially collapsed. Our soldiers can enter the fort through this dilapidated wall by climbing the mountain cliff.

SHIVAJI

What about the front gates?

PANT

About twenty feet tall...

ABBAJI VISHWANATH

I will lead the attack from the front with four hundred men. Malusure can standby if I need additional support.

(MORE)

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (cont'd)

I will create a diversion while my men will use our long ladders to scale the fort walls.

JEDDE

Netaji and I will scale the mountain with three hundred men and attack through the rear wall. Once the gates have fallen it should be easy to get to Krishnaji. Allow me, Raje, to win this fort for you. With seven hundred men I can take the fort before sunrise.

SHIVAJI

Jedde, we will need more than seven hundred men to take this fort.

NETAJI PALKAR

But Maharaj, what chance does the two hundred have against our seven hundred soldiers?

SHIVAJI

(looking at Pant)

Because, what our spy failed to tell Pant was that along with the two hundred men, the fort is defended by Baji Prabhu Deshpande.

PANT

Raje, who is this Baji Prabhu Deshpande?

SHIVAJI

Baji Prabhu is an iron wall against whom men break like egg shells. Rohida can't be taken as long as he stands guard.

(to Jedde)

Ready our full force.

INT. ROHIDA FORT - DAY

A scenic view of a VALLEY through A DILAPIDATED FORT WALL.

Baji Prabhu inspects the damage with Krishnaji, Moroji, Phulaji and Tatyia.

BAJI PRABHU

Krishnaji, it doesn't take more than two months to repair the wall.

(MORE)

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)
 What do you do with all the taxes you
 collect from people?

As Krishnaji searches for words--

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)
 (to Tatya)
 Tatyaji, have men work twenty four
 hours on this wall. We have to
 reinforce it as much as possible in
 the next ten days.

Tatya leaves.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)
 On the night of *amavasya* the attack
 will come. The enemy will scale the
 front walls with ladders.
 (pointing to the wall)
 Another attack will come from here. (
 (to Moroji)
 Reinforce the fort walls with oil and
 archers. Ensure no one goes in or out
 without permission. Double the guards
 on the walls.
 (to Phulaji)
 Dada, you hold the center of the fort
 with your men. Double the sentries at
 night and keeps your arms ready. I
 will guard the rear.
 (to Krishnaji)
 Maharaj, Phulaji will guard you at
 all times. Please do not leave his
 circle of protection. This is a
 battle where you don't have to take
 up arms. We will do that for you.

KRISHNAJI BANDAL
 I know you will Baji. You should have
 been the son I don't have. I will
 sleep in peace.

EXT. RAIGADH - COUNTRYSIDE - DAY

Shivaji Raje along with his Generals rides out with his war
 party towards Rohida.

INT. COURTYARD - ROHIDA FORT - DAY

MONTAGE

Men frantically working to repair the rear wall, Tatya pushing the men to be quicker.

In the courtyard, Baji Prabhu conducts sword fight drill with his men.

INT. ROHIDA FORT - FORT WALL - NIGHT

Baji Prabhu and Phulaji looking at the vast emptiness beyond the fort wall. A quite moment before the impending attack.

PHULAJI

I hear Shivaji has a group of fearless Generals who win battles for him.

BAJI PRABHU

Men are only as fearless as their leader, Dada. You know that better than anyone. You will have to protect Krishnaji at all costs. If he falls, the two hundred men will surrender without a fight.

PHULAJI

I will lay my life before I let the enemy reach Krishnaji. But isn't it suicide to try to hold the rear? Even with reinforcement the wall is barely able to hold.

BAJI PRABHU

Moroji and I will hold the line dada, I won't let a single Mavala soldier pass through the rear I can assure you that.

PHULAJI

Get some rest. We need all your strength for the fight.

Both the brothers know this fight isn't going to be easy to win. They lie down looking at the empty sky.

INT. ROHIDA FORT - GATE - NIGHT

TWO SENTRIES, ARMED, on beat.

SENTRY ONE

Since the day Baji Prabhu has arrived, I have barely slept.

SENTRY TWO
My body is broken from all the
training. I can barely stand.

BACK TO:

INT. ROHIDA FORT - FORT WALL - NIGHT

Baji Prabhu wakes up from his nap. He nudges Phulaji to wake up, then goes into--

INT. ROHIDA FORT - REAR WALL - CONTINUOUS

Moroji, Vishba and his men are on guard.

BAJI PRABHU
(to Moroji)
It's time. They must be climbing the
cliff already. Keep Vishba close,
he's too young not to see another
fight.

CUT TO:

FORT GATES

Through the tiny opening in the looming gates, a sentry sees someone approach the gates.

A person DRAPED IN A SHAWL walks toward the gate. His face illegible in the misty night.

SENTRY ONE
You there, stop!

The person stops on his tracks.

SENTRY TWO
Who are you? Reveal yourself!

The person lowers the shawl from his head to reveal ABBAJI VISHWANATH.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (O.S.)

(in a coarse village
accent)
I am Chintal Sule. But they all call
me Kaali on the account of my dark
complexion.
(MORE)

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (O.S.) (cont'd)
 (pointing somewhere
 in the darkness)
 I am from Lakshman Gadh, a village
 beyond that hill.

SENTRY ONE
 Chintal Sule from Lakshman Gadh. Why
 are you here?

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (O.S.)

 Sahib, I am a shepherd. This evening
 I was herding my sheep through the
 passage by the hill, I found this.

From the crack in the gates we see Abbaji Vishwanath thrust
 his palm forward with FIVE SILVER COINS.

Sentries' eyes widen seeing the shiny silver coins.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (O.S.) (cont'd)
 I brought them to check if they
 belonged to someone in the palace.

SENTRY TWO
 You did the right thing bringing them
 here. They are mine. Hand them to me.

Sentry Two shoving aside Sentry One...

SENTRY ONE
 (to Sentry Two)
 You are on duty since three days.
 When did you go out to drop them?
 Liar!
 (to Abbaji Vishwanath)
 They are mine. Pass them from under
 the gate.

Five silver coins slide from under the gate. Both the
 sentries tussle for the coins. Sentry Two scoops two and
 Sentry One gets three. As they pocket the coins--

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (O.S.)
 Sahib, these are only some of them. I
 found a bag full of those coins.

Sentries hear a BAG OF COINS JIGGLE.

Sentry One and Two look at each other, then fight for place
 to peep through the crack. They see--

ABBAJI HOLDING OUT A BAG.

Consumed by greed, they open the gate just a little and Sentry One stretches his hand out.

SENTRY ONE
(whispering)
Give the bag to me.

Sentry One screams and stumbles backward clutching his right arm.

Sentry Two freezes in horror as he watches BLOOD SPRAY FROM THE AMPUTATED ARM of Sentry One.

ABBAJI SQUEEZES THROUGH THE DOOR. HE DROPS HIS SHAWL. SENTRY TWO IS PETRIFIED WATCHING ABBAJI. AS HE TRIES TO PICK HIS SPEAR FROM THE GROUND--

ABBAJI SLASHES HIM IN THE CHEST. MALUSURE and his four hundred soldiers pour through the gate into the fort.

REAR WALL

The WAIL of the sentry One ECHOES through the fort.

A SOUND OF A BUGLE follows announcing the attack on the fort.

BAJI PRABHU
The enemy has arrived.

Baji Prabhu walks to the dilapidated wall and looks down. It is still dark but he knows the Mavala soldiers are crawling up the cliff.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)
Hurl those rocks now!

Baji Prabhu's men drop ROCKS down the cliff.

DISTANT SCREAMS of Mavala soldiers as the rocks knock them down the cliff.

COURT ROOM

Phulaji's men, armed and alert, form a human shield around Krishnaji Bandal.

KRISHNAJI BANDAL
Shivaji is here.

PHULAJI

Don't worry Krishnaji. He will have
to kill me to get to you.

FORT GATES

ARCHERS on the gates fire a VOLLEY OF ARROWS. The Mavala soldiers gather in a CLOSE FORMATION and take cover under their shields.

As the archers reload their arrows, Malusure breaks formation and hurls a his sword at the archers on the walls.

The sword PIERCES through an archer's chest and he falls from the wall.

REAR WALL

A line of archers dip their oiled arrows in a lamp.

BAJI PRABHU

Fire.

A volley of burning arrows pierce through the darkness as they go down the cliff. Some hit Mavala climbers on their way.

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)

Again.

Archers ready with flaming arrow stringed let loose another volley of arrows down the cliff.

CLIFF

Jedde, Netaji Palkar and their soldiers hide behind a rock as the flaming arrows fly past. They are less than fifty feet away from the wall.

JEDDE

(pointing at a
soldier taking
shelter behind a
rock)

You. Take fifteen men with you and
make a dash to the wall.

Another volley of fire arrows scream past them. Jedde and soldiers around him duck behind rocks and trees.

The soldier gestures to some of them men to follow him. As a soldier emerges from behind a boulder a flaming arrow pierces through his eye.

The small group moves with agility as they dodge flaming arrows and rocks along the rocky path to the wall.

Baji Prabhu, Moroji and Vishba stand ahead as a first line of defence.

The Mavala soldiers pour through the dilapidated wall. As they notice Baji and his men waiting, they grab their shield and swords from behind their backs.

Eyes locked, each waiting for the other to make the first move. A tense moment...

A Mavala soldier lunges forward with his sword. Baji Prabhu cuts him down in a swift move with his dandpatta. The rest of the Mavala soldiers lunge forward in an attack.

Baji Prabhu's men pounce on the enemy, FIERCELY STABBING AND SLICING. In no time the floor is littered with SEVERED BODY PARTS AND AMPUTATED BODIES of the Mavala soldiers.

Vishba disarms the last Mavala soldier standing and as he's about to put his sword through the soldier's neck--

BAJI PRABHU

Let him go.

(to the Mavala
soldier)

Tell your commander that Baji Prabhu
guards the fort. Tell him to turn
around or face similar fate.

The Mavala soldier jumps over the wall and disappears into the darkness.

OPEN AREA/FRONT GATE

Abbaji Vishwanath and his three hundred men are firmly inside the gate now. Krishnaji's soldiers put up a fierce resistance but are no match for Abbaji and Malusure's Mavala soldiers.

Abbaji and Malusure are on a rampage as they bulldoze their way head.

CLIFF

Jedde and his soldiers are on the move cautiously. Rocks and arrows have stopped coming from the fort.

A lone soldier sprinting down the cliff. He gets closer but no sign of slowing. Jedde grabs him and shoves him behind a boulder.

JEDDE

What happened to the others?

SOLDIER

(panting, frightened)

...all dead. ...they spared My
life...

(gasps for breath)

...to bring carry a message for you.

JEDDE

What message?

SOLDIER

Turn around... or ...die.

JEDDE

Who leads there?

SOLDIER

Baji Prabhu.

Jedde takes a beat. He this name could bring trouble.

JEDDE

How many men does he have fighting
with him?

SOLDIER

Less than Fifty.

SOLDIER (cont'd)

Less than Fifty ...but they fight
with the strength of five hundred.
Our men were cut down within minutes
we entered.

Jedde grasp the enormity of the situation.

JEDDE

(to a nearby soldier)

Send a word to Malusure at the front
gate. Tell him we may take longer
than planned to break through the
rear wall.

A SOLDIER bows and disappears into the darkness.

OPEN AREA/FRONT GATE

Abbaji Vishwanath and his three hundred men are firmly inside the gate now.

Abbaji Vishwanath charges forward slicing and stabbing his way, and is headed to...

INT. ROHIDA FORT - COURTYARD - CONTINUOUS

Abbaji walks into the courtyard to find--

Krishnaji surrounded by Phulaji and his men, ARMED AND READY.

Malusure and other men enter. The room is filled with anxiety on Phulaji and his men seeing a large force.

A stand off seems inevitable between a small group of Phulaji's men and hundreds of Mavala soldiers.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH
Surrender Krishnaji. Save your life
and the lives of your men. So many
people don't have to die needlessly.

KRISHNAJI BANDAL
Neither me not my men are afraid of
cowards like you who attack in the
cover of darkness. Come, fight me.

Krishnaji lunges forward with his sword, but Phulaji stops him.

PHULAJI
Krishnaji, these barbarians have to
cross me before they get to you.
(stepping forward,
speaking to Abbaji)
You can't get to him as long as I am
alive. Come.

Phulaji locks his eyes with Abbaji.

Mavala soldiers are drunk with ecstasy from easy victory so far. Ready for another fight, they wait for Abbaji's signal.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH
So be it.

As Abbaji steps forward swinging swords in both his hands. His men charge at Phulaji's men.

Abbaji walks straight to Krishnaji, cutting down anyone coming in his way.

Four Mavala soldiers keep Phulaji busy.

Phulaji notices Abbaji going straight to Krishnaji. He drops his shield, slices clean the hand of a Mavala soldier and takes his sword. He is on the offensive now. He must protect Krishnaji.

He throws himself on the men with big blows chopping a soldier's arm, another's head and stabbing another one.

Abbaji inches closer to Krishnaji. He stabs a soldier with both his swords, lifts him and hurls his body out of his way.

Krishnaji watches in horror the mayhem around him. Phulaji lunges towards Abbaji. A Mavala soldier comes in his way. PHULAJI DUCKS THE INCOMING SWORD AND SLASHES THE SOLDIER'S LEG.

As Abbaji gets closer, Krishnaji charges at him with sword raised high. Abbaji locks his sword arm under his elbow, looks into Krishnaji's eyes and slides his sword deep into him.

Phulaji watches in agony as Krishnaji falls. With Krishnaji dies the promise made by Phulaji's father to protect him.

Phulaji pounces on Abbaji with all his strength. Abbaji matches blow to blow. Phulaji and Abbaji lock swords, their breaths straining.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (cont'd)
Your king is dead. There is no reason
to continue to fight. Stop now. Save
your life. Save your men.

Phulaji pushes back Abbaji and pounces with his sword raised high. Abbaji parries the blow, knocks the sword from his hand and brings his sword to Phulaji's throat.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH (cont'd)
Look around. Your king would have
been able to save all these lives. He
was a selfish man. Don't be like him.
Stand down and save your life.

Phulaji looks around. Malusure stabs the last soldier fighting. The room is strewn with dead bodies. He is the last man standing.

Phulaji kneels beside Krishnaji's body, looks up to the sky--

PHULAJI

Forgive me father, I have failed in
honoring your pledge to the Bandals.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH

(to his men)

The fort is ours. Send the signal .

Baji Prabhu, covered in blood, enters the room, with Moroji and Vishba in tow. Sees Phulaji by Krishnaji's body. Enraged.

BAJI PRABHU

Who among you cowards killed
Krishnaji?

ABBAJI VISHWANATH

It is me. The war is over now. The
fort is in our control. Stand down.

BAJI PRABHU

The war is not over as long as Baji
Prabhu stands.

Jedde and Netaji Palkar enter. Baji Prabhu, eyes locked on Abbaji, raising his dandpatta--

BAJI PRABHU (cont'd)

Fight me.

ABBAJI VISHWANATH

You are surrounded and out numbered.

(raising his sword
and preparing to
attack)

If you want to die, I won't stop you.
Come on.

Malusure and his men lift their swords and shields, ready to engage Baji Prabhu's men.

As Abbaji is about to step in, he notices a hand on his shoulder. Turns around to see--

Shivaji and his men.

SHIVAJI

Abbaji you, Malusure and all the men you have can't take the fort as long as Baji stands.

(stepping toward Baji)

Baji, I have only heard of your skill and bravery. Today I saw what a dandpatta can become in a warrior's hands. There is no warrior as great as you in all of Maratha empire.

(puts his hand on
Baji dandpatta and
lowers it)

We have no fight with you.

SHIVAJI (cont'd)

I have not come to fight you. We need warriors like you to strengthen Swaraj, to fight along side us and strengthen our cause.

BAJI PRABHU

My father swore allegiance to Krishnaji and your men killed him. Now you ask me to join you. Tell me, what should an honorable soldier do?

SHIVAJI

A warrior must always stand by what is right. Without righteousness, there is no honor in defending a promise.

(beat)

Krishnaji is no more. You are no more bound by your father's oath. You take pride in honoring your father's oath although you knew Krishnaji was not an honorable man. His actions did not always serve the people of this kingdom. Now you have the opportunity to change that. I will return the fort to the family of Krishnaji Bandal. Let them rule honorably hence forth. But they must answer to me instead of Adil Shah.

Baji Prabhu sees sense in Shivaji's argument. Baji Prabhu looks around at the faces of his men surrounded by Mavala troops.

BAJI PRABHU

My men have fought bravely. They will follow me where I go.

SHIVAJI

Swaraj will greatly benefit with
addition of your brave men.

Baji Prabhu places his dandpatta at Shivaji's feet.

Shivaji hugs Baji Prabhu.

FADE OUT